

TABLE OF CONTENTS

RESEARCH REPORT · APRIL 2026 · HIGHER EDUCATION, INDIA

01

02

03

04

05

06

07

08

09

10

Executive Summary

Introduction

Market Overview

Problem Statement

Objectives & Scope

Methodology

Market Context

Competitive Landscape

Value Proposition

Regulatory Environment

Financial Model

Implementation Roadmap

A Common App for India's Private Universities

A feasibility analysis of building a non-profit, unified college application platform for India — covering market context, competitive landscape, value proposition, regulatory environment, sustainability, and an implementation roadmap.

SCOPE	MODEL	FOCUS	AUDIENCE
Private Universities, India	Non-Profit / Low-Cost	UG Admissions	Founders & Stakeholders

Pain Points in the Indian College Application Process

15.5M Grade 12 students navigate applications annually	43.3M Students currently enrolled in higher education	1,355 Universities in India (FY26), incl. 361 private universities	52,321 Colleges in India as of November 2025
--	---	--	--

India's college application process is one of the most fragmented in the world. Every year, over 15.5 million Grade 12 students individually navigate a maze of institution-specific portals, misaligned deadlines, and redundant paperwork — in a system designed decades ago that has not modernized at the same pace as student volume or internet penetration.

1.1 Fragmentation of Applications

Each private university operates its own application portal with its own login, its own form structure, its own document upload requirements, and its own fee. A student applying to ten private institutions must complete this process ten times from scratch. There is no "fill once, apply many" mechanism for private universities. This is the most fundamental structural flaw in the system, and it disproportionately burdens students from low-income backgrounds who have less time and fewer resources to dedicate to administrative overhead.

1.2 Information Asymmetry and Discovery Gap

A large proportion of Indian students — particularly those from Tier 2, Tier 3 cities, and rural areas — are unaware of the full spectrum of universities available to them. Discovery is largely word-of-mouth, limited by geography, or dependent on costly counsellors. Platforms like CollegeDekho and Shiksha help with discovery, but do not solve the actual application process. A student in Raigarh with a 92% board score may apply to only three or four colleges, simply because the process of applying to more feels overwhelming.

1.3 Redundant Documentation and Cumulative Fees

Students must upload identical documents — marksheets, photo IDs, passport photos, certificates — to every individual portal. Application fees, typically ranging from ₹500 to ₹2,000 per institution, quickly accumulate into a significant financial barrier. A student applying to 15 private institutions could spend ₹10,000–25,000 in fees alone, before any admission is confirmed.

1.4 Misaligned Timelines and Tracking Chaos

Unlike the US system where Common App provides centralized deadline tracking and application status visibility, Indian students must manually track individual deadlines across dozens of separate portals. There is no unified dashboard. Missed deadlines, incomplete submissions, and confusion about round-wise cutoffs are common outcomes.

1.5 Rural and First-Generation Applicant Disadvantage

Students from rural backgrounds often begin college research only after their board exams — too late for many private universities that open and close applications on different timelines. The lack of a standardized, accessible process creates an uneven playing field where a student's geographic location and family's familiarity with higher education have an outsized effect on their outcomes.

1.6 The CUET Gap — and Why It Does Not Solve This Problem

CUET (Common University Entrance Test), introduced under NEP 2020 and run by the National Testing Agency (NTA), is a centralized entrance exam that is **mandatory only for central (government-funded) universities** — such as Delhi University, JNU, BHU, JMI, and AMU. It standardizes the *entrance test* layer for these government institutions and does **not** function as a unified application platform for private universities.

Private universities are **not required** to adopt CUET. Only a small minority — approximately 30% of India's 361 private universities — have voluntarily opted in, and most of those are larger, better-resourced institutions such as Ashoka University and OP Jindal Global University. The remaining 70% of private universities maintain entirely separate entrance criteria, application portals, and admission processes. CUET therefore leaves the private university application ecosystem — the primary focus of this platform — entirely unaddressed.

CORE PROBLEM

India's private university application ecosystem is broken at the infrastructure layer. There is no common form, no shared document repository, no unified deadline tracker, and no single application fee — for the 361+ private universities that serve millions of underserved applicants annually. CUET solves this for central government universities; nothing solves it for private universities.

Demand for a Common App-Style Platform

Demand is both latent and emergent. It exists but has not yet been clearly articulated by students simply because no functional equivalent has existed for them to reference. The launch of Appli (2024–25, Bangalore) and its reported registration of 1.3 lakh users within eight months offers a meaningful early signal: students will migrate to a simpler process when offered one.

2.1 Structural Demand Drivers

- India's Gross Enrollment Ratio (GER) in higher education stands at 28.4% — far below the NEP 2020 target of 50% by 2030. Reducing application friction is one lever to push marginal students into enrolment.
- The number of universities grew from 760 in FY15 to 1,355 in FY26 — an 80% increase — and private universities now constitute the largest single category. Navigating this expanded landscape without a unified tool is increasingly untenable.
- India's Gen Z population exceeds 377 million. This cohort is mobile-native, expects digital-first experiences, and is deeply receptive to tools that simplify administrative complexity.
- The Indian higher education market is valued at ₹5.75 trillion (2024) and is projected to reach ₹11.60 trillion by 2033 at a CAGR of 8.1%, signalling rising institutional investment in recruitment infrastructure.

2.2 University-Side Demand

Private universities in India increasingly compete for students, particularly as more institutions enter the market. Smaller and mid-tier private universities often lack robust digital marketing budgets and rely on physical counsellors or education fairs for recruitment. A unified platform offering access to a broad pool of qualified applicants addresses a genuine recruitment problem for these institutions, not just an administrative convenience.

2.3 The CUET Signal — What It Teaches Us

CUET's rapid adoption — with over 12 lakh students applying in 2024 — demonstrates that students and central universities will rally around a centralized platform when it is authoritative, accessible, and perceived as legitimate. Importantly, CUET is a **government-run entrance exam platform for central universities**, not a model for private university applications. But its scale proves a key behavioural insight: students actively prefer consolidated, single-point systems over scattered portals. A purpose-built application platform for private universities — if designed with similar simplicity and trust — has a realistic path to comparable adoption.

DEMAND VERDICT

Demand is real, growing, and structurally supported. It is highest among mid-income, Tier 2/3-city students applying to 5–20 private universities — a segment currently underserved by every existing platform in the market.

Existing Competitors & Alternatives

No direct equivalent of Common App currently exists for India's private university landscape. Existing players operate in adjacent spaces — primarily discovery and lead generation — but not in unified application submission. This is the critical gap.

Platform	What They Do	What They Don't Do	Business Model	Threat
CollegeDekho	■ 222Cr revenue, 35,000+ colleges listed, counselling	No unified single-form application	Lead gen + admission commission	Medium
Shiksha.com	36M monthly visits, career guidance, college info portal	No application infrastructure	Lead generation sold to colleges	Low
Collegedunia	Discovery portal with strong SEO, reviews, rankings	No application processing	CPL + CPS model	Low
Careers360	Entrance exam info, editorial content, rankings	No student application tool	Advertising + subscriptions	Low
CUET (NTA)	Centralized entrance exam for central (govt.) universities like DU, JNU, BHU	Not an application platform; covers only govt. central universities, not private ones	Government-run, exam fees	Low
Appli (2025)	Mobile-first common application, 1.3L registered users, launched early 2025	Pre-revenue; limited network; for-profit	TBD (for-profit startup)	High

COMPETITIVE WHITE SPACE

Every major incumbent monetizes through lead generation, which means their incentive is NOT to help students apply efficiently — it is to channel students toward paying partner colleges. A non-profit with a student-first mandate, focused on application submission rather than lead generation, occupies genuinely uncontested territory. Appli is the only direct competitor but remains early-stage, for-profit, and under-resourced.

Potential Users & Stakeholders

4.1 Primary Users — Students

- **Tier 2 / Tier 3 city aspirants (Core Segment):** Students in cities like Raipur, Patna, Surat, Coimbatore applying to 5–15 private universities. Most affected by fragmentation and information asymmetry. Highest willingness to adopt a simpler platform.
- **First-generation college students:** No family guidance, no counsellor access. A structured single application provides crucial scaffolding and removes the "where do I even start" barrier.
- **Students from low-income households:** For whom cumulative application fees represent a genuine economic burden, and where the cost of a missed deadline is highest.
- **Urban students applying broadly:** Applying to 20+ universities who value time efficiency and centralized tracking.

4.2 Universities

- **Mid-tier private universities (₹2–10L annual fees):** Most to gain from access to a wider, geographically diverse applicant pool without paying high CPL/CPS fees to commercial platforms.
- **Newer private universities (established post-2015):** Lack brand recognition and struggle with organic applicant discovery. A common platform normalizes their presence alongside established names.
- **Socially conscious institutions:** Azim Premji University, Ashoka University, FLAME University — already inclined toward mission-aligned partnerships.

4.3 Ecosystem Stakeholders

- **UGC and Ministry of Education:** Aligned with NEP 2020 goals of widening access and reducing application burden. A non-profit platform could attract policy support.
- **School counsellors and teachers:** A unified platform with counsellor-facing features (recommendation uploads, tracking) would make their work significantly easier.
- **CSR arms of Indian corporations:** Education access is the largest CSR category. The platform's mission maps directly to CSR frameworks under the Companies Act 2013.
- **Philanthropic foundations:** Tata Trusts, Azim Premji Foundation, and international foundations (Gates, Lumina) fund access-oriented edtech.

Value Proposition — Students & Universities

5.1 For Students

Dimension	Current Reality	With the Platform
Application effort	Hours per institution × 10–20 institutions	One profile; applied to many with one click
Document uploads	Same files re-uploaded to every portal	Upload once, shared securely across applications
Application fees	■500–2,000 per institution (■10K–40K for 15+)	Zero fee to student (platform absorbs or waives)
Deadline tracking	Manual, institution-by-institution	Unified dashboard with automated reminders
Application status	Log into each portal separately	Single centralized status view across all applications
Discovery	Limited by geography / word-of-mouth	Full network of participating universities searchable

5.2 For Universities

- **Wider applicant reach:** Access to students from Tier 2/3 cities who would not have found or applied through existing channels.
- **Reduced per-student acquisition cost:** Instead of paying ■800–3,000 CPL to commercial lead-gen platforms, universities receive qualified applications at minimal cost.
- **Standardized application data:** Consistent data format across all applicants reduces manual processing time for admissions teams.
- **Brand visibility:** Listing alongside peer institutions on a trusted platform improves perceived legitimacy, especially for newer universities.
- **Analytics:** Aggregate application data (interests, geography, scores) helps institutions understand demand and refine programs.

Feasibility of a Non-Profit / Low-Cost Model

The Common App in the US provides a direct proof-of-concept: a non-profit organization can build and operate a unified college application platform at scale. Common App is funded primarily through membership fees paid by universities and a small per-application commission — not by students. It serves 3 million students and 1,100+ colleges annually.

6.1 Why Non-Profit is the Right Structure for India

- A for-profit model creates misaligned incentives. Once monetized through commissions, the platform will naturally favour universities who pay more — replicating the lead-gen model's flaws.
- Non-profit status enables access to CSR funds under the Companies Act 2013 (Schedule VII), which mandates Indian companies with net profit above ₹5Cr to spend 2% on CSR, including education.
- A non-profit is more likely to receive government endorsement or official tie-ins with NEP 2020 initiatives, giving it a trust advantage over commercial players.
- Trust is a critical adoption factor. Universities need assurance that applicant data will not be commercially exploited. Non-profit governance provides that credibility.

6.2 Operational Viability Estimate

A minimal-viable non-profit platform covering 50 universities and 200,000 students/year could operate on a budget of approximately ₹2–4 crore per year, covering technology infrastructure, a core team of 8–12 people, university onboarding, and student communications. This is well within the range of what CSR grants, institutional memberships, and foundation funding can sustain in Year 1–3.

FEASIBILITY VERDICT

Non-profit is not just feasible — it is the strategically correct structure. It enables the platform to prioritize student access over commercial returns, unlocks CSR and philanthropic funding channels, and builds the trust necessary for university participation. The Common App's financial model (university membership + modest per-application fee) translates reasonably well to the Indian context.

Regulatory, Operational & Technical Challenges

7.1 Regulatory Landscape

India's higher education is regulated by a complex multi-layered system involving UGC, AICTE (technical programmes), the Ministry of Education at the centre, and state-level regulatory bodies. Key considerations:

- **No mandate exists** for private universities to adopt any centralized application system. Participation must be entirely voluntary, which means the value proposition must be compelling enough to drive adoption without regulatory pressure.
- **Data protection:** India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act (DPDPA), 2023, creates compliance obligations around collection and processing of student data. Explicit consent, data minimization, and clear retention policies are non-negotiable.
- **Non-profit registration:** The entity should be registered under Section 8 of the Companies Act (non-profit company). FCRA registration is required if accepting foreign grants.
- **State-level variation:** Private university regulations differ significantly by state. Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Karnataka, and Rajasthan have the highest density of private universities — each with distinct state-level oversight bodies.

7.2 Operational Challenges

- **University onboarding inertia:** Private universities with established processes have little immediate incentive to change systems. Early adopters must see a clear and fast benefit — likely through increased applications from geographies they weren't previously reaching.
- **Heterogeneous requirements:** Indian private universities differ dramatically in what they require — some use SoPs, some use their own entrance tests, some use only board marks. The platform must be flexible enough to accommodate diverse form structures.
- **Language and digital literacy:** Serving Tier 2/3 city students requires support for regional languages (at minimum Hindi + major South Indian languages) and an interface designed for lower digital literacy.
- **Counsellor intermediary resistance:** A large informal industry of private counsellors charges students to manage applications. This platform partially disintermediates that industry, which may create friction.

7.3 Technical Challenges

- **DigiLocker integration:** India's government-run DigiLocker enables digital storage and sharing of verified documents. Integration eliminates manual document uploads — a major usability win that should be prioritized from Day 1.
- **Integration with university systems:** Each university uses different back-end software (or none at all). The platform needs flexible APIs or export formats compatible with a heterogeneous tech stack.
- **Scalability during peak load:** The application cycle is intensely seasonal (June–July). The platform must handle millions of concurrent submissions. Infrastructure design for burst capacity is non-trivial.
- **Mobile-first architecture:** A substantial proportion of students access the internet primarily via mobile. The platform must be designed mobile-first, not mobile-responsive as an afterthought.

Monetization & Sustainability Options

Sustainability does not require commercial monetization in the traditional sense. The non-profit structure allows for a diversified revenue/funding model that keeps the student experience free and keeps university costs minimal.

Revenue Stream	Description	Est. Potential	Risk
University Membership Fees	Annual fee for universities to list and receive applications. Tiered by institution size. Eg. 50 universities × ■1–3L = ■50L–1.5Cr/yr	■50L–1.5Cr/yr	Medium
Per-Application Fee	Small fee (■20–50) per submitted application charged to university. At 10L applications, yields ■2–5Cr/yr	■2–5Cr/yr (at scale)	Low
CSR Funding	Indian corporates spent ■26,000+ Cr on CSR in FY24; education is the largest category. Mission fits well.	■1–5Cr initial grant	Low
Philanthropic Grants	Tata Trusts, Azim Premji Foundation, Lumina Foundation, Gates Foundation have active India education access programmes	■2–10Cr multi-year	Low
Premium Analytics	Aggregate, anonymized data dashboards for universities (applicant trends, geography, score bands). Optional add-on.	■1–3Cr/yr at scale	Low
Scholarship Partner Listings	Education loan providers (HDFC Credila, Avanse) and scholarship bodies pay to list offerings to students. No student data sold.	■50L–1Cr/yr	Medium

SUSTAINABILITY PATHWAY

In Year 1–2, operations are funded through CSR grants and philanthropic capital (■2–5Cr). By Year 3–4, with 50+ university members and 200,000+ applications, university membership and per-application fees create a self-sustaining model without reliance on advertising or commercial lead generation. This is the Common App's path adapted to India's funding landscape.

Risks, Limitations & Adoption Challenges

9.1 Adoption Risk — The Cold-Start Problem (Highest Risk)

Without universities, the platform has no value for students; without students, universities have no incentive to join. This classic cold-start problem is the defining challenge. Early strategy must prioritize signing 15–25 founding university partners before public launch to provide simultaneous legitimacy and student demand.

9.2 Competitive Response from Incumbents

CollegeDekho already has early-stage "apply to multiple colleges" functionality and the capital to build this out rapidly. Their revenue model (commission-based) is fundamentally different, but they could undercut on price temporarily. The non-profit positioning and mission-driven branding is the best long-term defence.

9.3 Appli — The Direct Competitor

Appli has early-mover advantage and 1.3 lakh registered users as of early 2025. It is for-profit and Bangalore-focused. Strategic responses: compete on mission and national reach; or explore partnership/collaboration (a non-profit collaborating with an existing tech platform is not uncommon in the global edtech space).

9.4 Heterogeneity of Indian Higher Education

India's private university ecosystem is far more diverse in admission criteria, processes, and tech maturity than the US system that Common App serves. Some Indian institutions still process applications via physical forms. Building a platform that serves a Manipal University and a first-generation private university in Jharkhand requires significant configuration flexibility and concierge-level onboarding support.

9.5 Trust and Data Privacy Concerns

Any perception that student data is being sold to universities — as commercial lead-gen platforms do — could be fatal to adoption. Transparent data governance, clear DPDPA compliance, and a public privacy charter are non-negotiable. A university cannot receive more than what a student explicitly submitted to them.

9.6 Non-Profit Governance Overhead

Indian non-profits face significant governance and compliance overhead: annual filings, third-party audits, board governance, and (if receiving foreign grants) FCRA registration and reporting. This requires experienced legal and financial management from Day 1.

HIGHEST RISK

The platform lives or dies on the cold-start problem: universities will not join without students, and students will not come without universities. A sequenced go-to-market strategy that locks in 20–30 founding university partners before public launch is the single most critical de-risking action available.

Verdict & Implementation Roadmap

OVERALL ASSESSMENT

Viable — With the Right Sequencing

This idea addresses a genuine, large, and structurally underserved problem in one of the world's largest higher education markets. The competitive white space is real. The non-profit model is the right structure. The demand signals — from CUET's scale (proving students adopt centralized systems), Appli's early traction, and India's growing private university sector — are encouraging. The primary challenge is not technical or financial: it is adoption sequencing and trust-building with private universities. Executed correctly, this platform could become foundational infrastructure for Indian private higher education within a decade.

Implementation Roadmap

01

Foundation & Legal Setup
(Months 1–6)

Register as Section 8 non-profit company. Form an advisory board with 2–3 respected university administrators, an education policy expert, and a tech leader. Draft data governance charter. File FCRA registration if targeting international grants. Assemble a founding team: 1 tech lead, 1 university partnerships lead, 1 operations/legal.

02

Founding University Partners
(Months 4–10)

Target 20–30 private universities. Focus on Tier 2/3 city universities and mission-aligned institutions (Azim Premji, Shiv Nadar, FLAME, Christ, Symbiosis). Offer founding member status: zero cost for 2 years, co-design rights, early analytics access. Secure letters of intent before platform build. Ideal founding geography: Karnataka, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan.

03

MVP Build
(Months 6–14)

Build core platform: student profile (one-time fill), university discovery, application submission, DigiLocker integration, deadline tracker, and admissions dashboard for universities. Mobile-first, Hindi + English. Ensure DPDPA compliance and a third-party security audit before launch.

04

Pilot Launch
(Months 14–18)

Launch in one or two states (Karnataka and Maharashtra recommended: highest private university density). Target 50,000 student applications in the first cycle. Partner with state-level school boards for awareness. Run a counsellor programme — equip school teachers to champion the platform. Measure: application completion rates, university satisfaction, student time savings.

05

National Scale
(Months 18–36)

Expand to all states. Onboard 100+ universities. Introduce per-application fees (₹30–50/application). Launch premium analytics for universities. Pursue UGC recognition. Begin regional language expansion (Tamil, Telugu, Marathi, Bengali). Target 5 lakh applications/year by end of Year 3.

Critical Success Factors

- **Solve the cold-start problem first.** Do not build before you have university commitments. Letters of intent from 20 universities are worth more than the best technology.
- **Stay narrow.** Be the application platform. Not the counselling platform. Not the test prep platform. Do one thing better than anyone else.
- **Non-profit credibility must be demonstrated, not assumed.** Publish all governance documents, audited financials, and data policies publicly. Radical transparency is the moat.
- **DigiLocker integration is a must-have, not a nice-to-have.** It eliminates the document burden in one stroke — a competitive advantage no commercial player has fully exploited.
- **Target first-generation students explicitly.** A free platform with guided application support and regional language access is transformative for this segment — and creates the clearest mission impact story for funders.
- **Build a counsellor programme.** Equip school teachers and government school counsellors to use and recommend the platform. This is how Common App won in the US — through institutional channels, not direct consumer marketing.

Summary Scorecard

HIGH Problem Severity & Structural Need	REAL Demand Signal (Student & University)	MODERATE Competitive Threat Level	VIABLE Non-Profit Sustainability	MEDIUM Regulatory Complexity	HIGH Cold-Start Adoption Risk
--	---	--	---	---	--